FINAL

THE SUN

LIGHT FOR ALL

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CHUCK KENNEDY : KNIGHT RIDDER/TRIBUNE

Senate Majority Leader Bill Frist, a Tennessee Republican, talks to reporters in the Capitol. Frist seeks a simple majority vote on judicial nominations.

Frist driving toward Senate rules showdown

Centrists might hold key to compromise in judicial fight

By GWYNETH K. SHAW
SUN NATIONAL STAFF

WASHINGTON — With a group of centrist senators scrambling to head off a confrontation, Senate Majority Leader Bill Frist will start the process of creating one this morning.

The move toward settling the simmering debate over judicial nominations, after months of inching toward a showdown, leaves a handful of undecided Republicans holding sway in a situation that has left most of their colleagues bitterly divided.

Frist, a Tennessee Republican, is to bring the nomination of Texas Supreme Court Justice Priscilla Owen up for discussion on the Senate floor, kicking off what is likely to be a multiday process filled with speeches and parliamentary maneuvering. Ultimately, Frist plans to use any effort to block Owen's confirmation as a chance to change the Senate's rules to guarantee a simple majority vote on judicial nominations.

But three Republicans — Sens. John McCain, Olympia J. Snowe and Lincoln Chafee — have said they will vote against such a rule change. Seven others, including Sens. Susan M. Collins, Chuck Hagel and John W. Warner, have refused to say publicly how they will vote, although some will likely side with Frist when the ultimate moment comes.

Considering [*See Judges, 7A*]

No stated position

These seven Republicans have not said publicly how they will vote on the rule change proposed by Senate Majority Leader Bill Frist. Three others oppose it. To keep their filibuster power, Democrats need three more votes from among these senators:

Sen. Susan M. Collins

Sen. Mike DeWine

Sen. Chuck Hagel

Sen. Lisa Murkowski

Sen. Arlen Specter

Sen. John E. Sununu

Sen. John W. Warner

Seaports still seen vulnerable to attacks

Poor planning, communications lapses hampering safety efforts, panel is told

'Consequences in the billions of dollars'

By MICHAEL DRESSER
SUN STAFF

WASHINGTON — Despite extensive efforts to improve security in the aftermath of the Sept. 11 attacks, the nation's seaports remain highly vulnerable to terrorists, a congressional investigator told senators yesterday.

Poor planning, communications lapses and a lack of clear goals are hampering efforts to make U.S. ports safer, said Margaret Wrightson, the Government Accountability Office's director of homeland security and justice issues.

Testifying before a Senate committee, Wrightson warned that seaports represent a possible conduit for terrorist groups to smuggle weapons of mass destruction into the country. She also warned of the economic consequences of any disruption of the flow of commerce.

"A successful attack on a seaport could result in a dramatic slowdown in the supply system, with consequences in the billions of dollars," she wrote in a report to Congress.

The GAO warning came the same day a bipartisan group of senators introduced legislation to step up transportation security, with an emphasis on ports and railroads.

Among other things, the bill would require importers to provide more information about cargo shipments before they [*See Ports, 4A*]

Making a play to bring diversity to video games

By ABIGAIL TUCKER AND RASHEIM FREEMAN
SUN STAFF

Black men go on digitized rampages. Hispanics field fly balls made of pixels. Black women are routinely the victims of crimes. Hispanic women rarely appear at all.

The video game industry, which had $7.3 billion in sales last year, claims a good deal of Americans' leisure time. About half of the country, spanning the races, plays some form of video game.

Nonetheless, though most modern games are three-dimensional, their portrayals of race are often one-dimensional.

Part of the problem, industry experts say, is that most video game designers are white men.

A Maryland-based initiative to be launched in Baltimore this summer hopes to alter that. The Urban Video Game Academy is looking for young game makers from diverse backgrounds who might add authentic ethnic perspectives to the industry.

"You can't change the stories unless you develop new storytellers," said Roderick Weldon Woodruff, president and co-founder of AAGamer, short for African American Gamer, a Columbia-based advocacy group that is help- [*See Games, 8A*]

Jack Abramoff promised much at Eshkol Academy. But corruption allegations would crumble his empire.

JED KIRSCHBAUM : SUN STAFF

"People started with high expectations and high desires," says Tova NessAiver of Baltimore, whose sons Avisha (left) and Shalev attended Eshkol Academy.

How lobbyist's troubles felled Columbia school

By ELLEN GAMERMAN
SUN STAFF

The abandoned school in Columbia, its black and gold team colors still painted on the walls, holds the dusty remains of a Washington operator's grand plans.

The Eshkol Academy, founded by super-lobbyist Jack Abramoff, promised a top-flight Orthodox Jewish education and gleaming facilities. Eshkol, its crest a raging lion, advertised all the privileges of a power school — a state-of-the-art sports program, a path to a fine college, a means to a sparkling resume.

But a year ago, after two problem-filled terms, Abramoff stepped onto the school grounds from his chauffeured limousine and announced that Eshkol would close its doors.

Graduation was just a month away, but no matter. Eshkol was over.

At that moment, Abramoff's empire was crumbling under intense scrutiny. The Justice Department was examining whether the powerful lobbyist — who earned millions of dollars representing, among others, American Indian casino interests — used nonprofit organizations to fund improper activities. Several months later, he would appear before a Senate committee and [*See School, 8A*]

Auditors question ethics of Md. DOT official

Manager oversaw work by husband's employer

By GREG GARLAND
SUN STAFF

A top Maryland transportation official inappropriately oversaw $3.3 million in poorly documented consulting work done for the state by a company that employs her husband, according to an audit report released yesterday.

The auditors, who turned their findings over to law enforcement authorities for review, said the official's actions appear to violate state ethics law and internal policies of the Maryland Department of Transportation governing conflicts of interest.

Auditors did not name the "senior management official" in their report, but a source familiar with the investigation identified her as Marsha J. Kaiser, director of the office of planning and capital programming for the Transportation Department.

Records that Kaiser filed with the State Ethics Commission in Annapolis confirm that her husband, Robert, works in the Glen Burnie offices of Pittsburgh-based Michael Baker Jr. Inc., which received 17 state transportation planning contracts worth more than $3 million from 1999 to 2004.

Neither [*See Audit, 6A*]

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